

operations were rather limited; there were only some 60 workers employed in the factory. The pilot training school was much more active. It was, in fact, the largest private flying school in the U.S.

I'd just returned from a trip to Europe, which was already at war. I was convinced that the United States

24

would eventually have to throw its weight into the war against the Axis. Consequently, I felt Spartan Aircraft would have an increasingly important role in the nation's defense program—but I could not guess then how very important it was destined to be.

Two years to the day after my first visit to Spartan, the Japanese attacked Pearl Harbor and the United States was at war. It was in that same month that my beloved mother died. It was a heavy blow. Although I was by then almost 50, I felt the loss as keenly as though I had still been a youngster.

War news filled the newspapers. I had not been allowed to serve in World War One, and I now hoped for the chance to serve in the second world conflict. I had studied celestial navigation and had owned—at various times in my life—

three yachts, the largest a 260-foot, 1500-tonner with a crew of 45. On the basis of this, I volunteered for service in the United States Navy. To my chagrin, I was politely but firmly informed that the Navy didn't have much use for a middle-aged businessman unless he was willing to take a routine, shore-based administrative job. After exhausting all other avenues, I obtained an interview with Navy Secretary Frank Knox and pleaded my case. I told him I wanted a Navy commission and sea duty.

"You qualify for a commission as an administrative or supply officer," Secretary Knox declared. "But sea duty is out of the question." He paused and studied me closely. "I understand you hold a large interest in the Spartan Aircraft Corporation," he said after a moment. I agreed that I did.